

Splink: The Full Report (v2 — expanded & corrected)

Who uses the Ministry of Justice's citizen record-linkage tool, who doesn't, and what it means

Public-interest research from publicly available documents. Compiled 4 June 2026. Two deep-research passes plus direct review of Splink's official "Use Cases" documentation (the maintainer-curated, authoritative adopter list). Confidence flagged; corrections from the first version noted openly.

Corrections to v1 (made openly): (1) **Germany (Destatis) IS a confirmed user** — register-based census linkage; v1 wrongly discarded it after checking the wrong sources. (2) **Canada IS an adopter** — v1 wrongly called it a "non-adopter"; in fact the Ontario Ministry of Children, Community & Social Services uses Splink as its *main* data-integration tool, and Environment & Climate Change Canada uses it too.

1. Executive summary

Splink (UK Ministry of Justice; Fellegi-Sunter; ADR UK-funded; ~6M downloads) joins separate records about the same person — with no shared ID — into linked records at population scale.

Documented adoption is **broader than the first pass showed**, and concentrated in the public sector: **~8 countries plus two international organisations** have publicly documented government use, on top of pervasive UK use and academic uptake. The driver is the **English-language data-science + open-source + academic network**, not a political alliance (it spans the EU, the UN, Africa and SE Asia).

The civil-liberties core is unchanged: where governments deploy it, they fuse sensitive citizen records with **no individual consent, notification, or opt-out** — and it now reaches **refugee data (UNHCR)**.

2. CONFIRMED government / public-sector adopters

(Source: Splink official Use Cases documentation + the cited primary sources.)

 **United Kingdom** — pervasive, national + local

ONS (Census, Business & Demographic Index), NHS England (Person_ID linkage service), Ministry of Justice (courts/prisons/probation cross-justice ID + BOLD probation dashboards), Ministry of Defence (Veterans Card), UK Health Security Agency (HIV↔health records), Department for Education (learner matching), Competition & Markets Authority, Office for Health Improvement & Disparities (health↔justice), Homes England (Land Registry↔Ordnance Survey, 30M records), Department for Business & Trade, Welsh Revenue Authority (operational tax), **and numerous local councils** — Lewisham (auto-enrolled 500+ families for Free School Meals), Leicestershire, Gateshead, Richmond, Wandsworth, Westmorland & Furness ("single view of the child"), London Office of Technology & Innovation (rough-sleeping). *Operational, deep.*

 **Australia** — ABS: Person Linkage Spine (Medicare+Centrelink+Tax); National Disability Data Asset. *Operational.*

 **Germany** — Federal Statistical Office (Destatis): linking register-based census data. *Operational.*

 **United States** — Defense Health Agency/DoD (dedup 200M+ hospital records); Florida Cancer Registry (feasibility); Catalyst Cooperative (utility data). *Mixed: operational + research.*

 **Canada** — Ontario Ministry of Children, Community & Social Services (**main** data-integration tool); Environment & Climate Change Canada. *Operational.*

 **Chile** — Ministry of Health (with UCL): migrant immunisation-access linkage. *Research.*

 **Gambia** — 2024 national census + post-enumeration survey linkage. *Operational (census).*

 **Laos (Lao PDR)** — Shared Child Health Record: pediatric record de-duplication (non-Latin script). *Operational (health).*

International organisations

-  **European Medicines Agency** — detecting duplicate adverse-event reports (veterinary medicines).

-  **UNHCR (UN Refugee Agency)** — identifying/addressing duplicates in datasets. (**Refugee data.**)

Academia (broader still)

University of Cambridge (CAMPOP — full-count census linking 1851–1921); Harvard / Vanderbilt / Mass General Brigham (8.1M death records↔EHR); Princeton / Minnesota; Stanford; **Bern, Switzerland**; UPenn / Princeton / UC Berkeley (108M individuals: property↔voter files↔donations); Lao PDR child health.

3. Negatives & null results (still useful)

-  **Poland** — no Splink; GUS does its own register-based census linkage.
 -  **Israel** — no Splink; Ofek national HIE + HMO-linked EHRs (its own infrastructure).
 -  **Scotland / Wales** — Public Health Scotland, NRS, and Wales' SAIL Databank do extensive linkage via their *own* TTP/MRL systems; no Splink found.
 -  **New Zealand** — IDI links via Fellegi-Sunter (the method), no documented Splink.
 -  **Ireland (CSO)** — Protected Identifier Key (PIK) system; no Splink found.
 - **No evidence:** Netherlands, Norway, Sweden, Finland, Denmark, France, Spain, Italy, Eurostat, Brazil, South Africa, India.
 - **Statistics Canada (the NSI)** — not shown using it, *even though other Canadian government bodies do*.
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4. The pattern — corrected

Not Commonwealth (Canada uses it *provincially* but NZ doesn't; Australia does), not Five-Eyes (spans the **EU, UN, Gambia, Laos, Switzerland, Chile**). The real driver: a **free, open-source UK-government tool** spreading through the **English-language statistics community, academic collaborations (UCL→Chile), open-source distribution, and international development/health projects** (Gambia census, Laos child health, UNHCR). Language + open source + research/aid networks — not geopolitics.

4.5 The bigger picture — Splink is one window into a global norm

Splink is a visible *thread*; the fabric is far larger. **Linking citizens' records without individual consent is now the dominant — and fast-growing — model of official statistics**, internationally endorsed:

- **UNECE 2020 census round (48 countries):** 14 (29%) **fully register-based**, 12 (25%) **combined** — i.e. **~54% built their census on linked administrative/register data**; only 46% still traditional. (*UNECE, "Overview of the 2020 round of censuses."*)
- **2030 round:** about **half** of UNECE countries expect to go **fully register-based**, and "most others expect to use administrative data partly." The door-to-door census is being retired.
- **Nordic countries** (Denmark, Sweden, Finland, Norway) have run **fully register-based** population systems for **decades** — the model the UK, NZ and Australia are now adopting.
- **OECD & UN** guidance **explicitly permits** statistical/health data linkage "subject to safeguards," and notes the legal bases that allow it **without individual consent** "vary by country."

The mechanism is the whole point: register-based statistics *inherently* link a person's records across government **without asking them** — the legal basis is **statute, not consent**. So the consent gap is **not** a UK quirk or a Splink quirk. It is **structural to how modern states now count and know their populations** — a near-universal default, expanding toward total coverage by 2030. Splink is simply one of the most *visible and open-source* instances of a practice almost every developed state already runs, and the rest are adopting.

5. Why it matters (+ fair counter-case)

Concern: sensitive citizen records fused into person-level profiles, no consent/notification/opt-out, drifting from statistics to operational identification (UK real-time court use; PNC lookups) — now reaching **refugee data (UNHCR)** and **child health records (Laos)**.

Counter-case (for credibility): lawful; accurate method; real safeguards (Five Safes, accredited researchers, secure environments, de-identification); genuine public goods; open-source = more transparent than proprietary tools. **Synthesis:** the quiet, lawful normalisation of cross-domain citizen linkage without meaningful consent — pioneered deepest in the UK, now documented across ~8 countries + the EU and UN, and mirrored everywhere by each state's own systems.

5.5 Legal standing & the GDPR paradox

(Informed analysis, not a legal opinion — a data-protection specialist should pressure-test any specific claim before publication.)

The instinct is "surely this breaks GDPR." **It almost certainly does not** — and the accurate finding is far stronger than an alleged violation would be.

GDPR does not require consent. Consent is just one of six lawful bases (Art 6). State data-linkage runs on: - **Art 6(1)(e)** — a task in the **public interest / official authority** (the workhorse for census, official statistics, public health). - **Art 6(1)(c)** — legal obligation.

GDPR is deliberately engineered to permit statistical linkage: - **Art 89** — a carve-out for "processing for statistical purposes," subject to safeguards (pseudonymisation, data minimisation). - **Art 5(1)(b)** — further processing for statistical purposes is **expressly not "incompatible"** with the original collection purpose; this defuses the purpose-limitation objection. - **Art 14(5)(b)** — a controller may **skip informing individuals** where notification is impossible or "disproportionate effort." *This is the legal home of the entire consent gap — the article that makes the silence lawful.* - **Recital 162** and **Regulation (EU) 223/2009 (European Statistics)** explicitly accommodate official statistics.

Precision on the EU body: the **European Medicines Agency** is an EU institution, so its processing falls under **Regulation (EU) 2018/1725 (the EUDPR)** — GDPR's sibling for EU bodies — **not GDPR itself**. Same principles, different instrument. (A lawyer will catch this; cite it correctly.)

The paradox — the real story

The world's strongest privacy law legally authorises the very thing people assume it protects them from. GDPR does not prohibit mass, non-consensual, cross-domain linkage of citizens' records — it supplies the lawful basis (public task), the statistics exemption, *and* the carve-out that means the individual is never told. The consent gap is **not an illegality. It is legal by design.**

This reframes the issue from *criminal* to *democratic*: nobody has to break GDPR, because GDPR blesses it. The defence "but it's fully GDPR-compliant" becomes the indictment.

Genuine legal pressure points (where it is arguable): data minimisation (Art 5(1)(c)) vs. linking everything to everything; transparency (Arts 13–14) vs. the disproportionate-effort silence; the right to object (Art 21) being curtailed for statistical processing; and whether the **Data Protection Impact Assessments** (Art 35) required for this high-risk processing are adequate — or even published.

6. The honest count

- **Confirmed government/public-sector adopters: ~8 countries** (UK, Australia, Germany, US, Canada, Chile, Gambia, Laos) + **2 international bodies** (EU/EMA, UNHCR).
- **UK is by far the deepest** (national agencies + many local councils).
- **Academic use: at least 4 countries** (US, UK, Switzerland, Laos).
- **Confirmed/likely non-users:** Poland, Israel, Scotland & Wales (own systems), NZ, Ireland, + ~10 others with no evidence.
- **Credit scoring/credit bureaus: UNVERIFIED. Excluded.**
- **True footprint is larger still** — open-source, ~6M downloads, no user registry; undocumented use exists but isn't nameable.

7. Method & sourcing

2 deep-research passes (adversarial 2-of-3 verification) + direct review of Splink's official Use Cases page + per-country sweeps (incl. Polish & Hebrew). Primary source for the international list: [moj-analytical-services.github.io/splink](https://github.com/moj-analytical-services/splink) (Use Cases). Negatives and corrections reported openly.